SHIP TYPES 1.2 · 10 MIN

Deadweight, Volume and Linear-Dimension Carriers

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What Runs Out First When You Load the Ship

Deadweight carriers

Heavy cargo, SF below about 1.3 m³/t. The load line is reached with hold space left. CF below about 1.5 m³/t DWT.

Bulk and ore carriers, crude tankers, tramp cargo ships

Volume carriers

Light cargo, SF above about 2.0 m³/t. The holds are full before the load line; excess freeboard. CF above about 2.5 m³/t DWT.

Ro-Ro, car carriers, Ro-Pax, container ships, reefers, liners, cruise ships

Linear-dimension ships

One of L, B, T or D is fixed by a canal, a port, a river or the size of the cargo unit.

Panamax ships, Great Lakes bulk carriers, cellular container ships

Special-purpose ships

Sized by a mission: bollard pull, ice class, fish hold, deck work. No general method.

Tugs, icebreakers, fishing and offshore vessels, fast craft

Cargo between 1.3 and 2.0 m³/t, or cargoes that vary a lot: the ship can be designed either way.

Stowage Factor and Capacity Factor

A PROPERTY OF THE CARGO

SF = volume to stow 1 t

m^3/t. Ore, cement, coal, grain, oil: low. Cotton, tobacco, fruit, cars, electronics: high.

A PROPERTY OF THE SHIP

CF = hold volume / DWT

m^3/t DWT. Set by the designer, through depth, beam and the shape of the holds.

Roughly: cargo with **SF below the ship's CF** fills the deadweight first; cargo with **SF above CF** fills the holds first. The designer picks CF for the cargo the ship will carry.

The Category Sets Where the Design Starts

Deadweight carrier

Start from DWT → displacement Δ

1. Length L, from L/∇^(1/3)
2. Block coefficient CB, from Fn
3. Beam B, from L/B and B/T
4. Draught T, from B/T and L/T
5. Depth D, from hold volume and L/D
6. CM, CP, CWP

Volume carrier

Start from hold volume or TEU

1. Length L, from bale volume or TEU
2. CB, from L and Fn; then B and D
3. Lightship, from L·B·D
4. DWT, from cargo, fuel and stores
5. Δ = lightship + DWT
6. Draught T, from Δ, L, B, CB

For a volume carrier the draught comes **last**, as a result; for a deadweight carrier it is fixed early.

When One Dimension Is Fixed from Outside

Constraint	Largest ship allowed	Fixes
Panama Canal, old locks (Panamax)	LOA 294.13 m · B 32.31 m · T 12.04 m	Beam, draught
Panama Canal, new locks (Neopanamax)	LOA 366 m · B 51.25 m · T 15.2 m	Beam, draught
St Lawrence Seaway (Seawaymax)	LOA 225.5 m · B 23.8 m · T 8.08 m	Beam, length
Azores island ports	Draught and berth length, each port	To be checked, port by port
ISO container (ISO 668)	8 ft = 2.438 m wide; 8 ft 6 in standard, 9 ft 6 in high-cube	Beam and depth, in steps

The cost: dimensions jump in steps and the proportions suffer. A 3rd-generation Panamax container ship of about 3,700 TEU: B = 32.2 m, L = 245 m, **L/B = 7.6**.

Which Category Is the Reference Ship?

- Is it the weight of the cargo or the tank volume that runs out first?
- Which line of the brief fixes a main dimension from outside?
- Do the ports on the route limit draught or length?
- So: does the design start from deadweight or from volume?